



WATCH OUR
VIDEO

THE PRICE OF DOMINANCE

While Indian women's cricket continues its supremacy in Asia with its gold run in Aichi-Nagoya, genuine competitiveness across the continent remains a **distant reality** despite the sport's growing footprint in the region.

Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan
lavanya.ln@thehindu.co.in

Sport is a kind of conquest. Rulers often get one significant, special coronation that cements their legacy before their followers. Sport, though, offers that sensational feeling of 'taking over the horizon' on a platter, again and again, patiently allowing those who persevere to have their fill.

The Indian women's cricket team (**facing page**) knows the feeling, with two such anointments in the span of a week, when it was undisputedly crowned the best in Asia — a record-extending eighth Women's Asia Cup title in Dubai and a savoured gold medal at the Asian Games in Japan, both against the same opponent in the final: Sri Lanka. Two summit clashes, two similar submissions to authority.

A marauding top order headlined India's unopposed quest for glory, both in Dubai and Nagoya. The tempestuous youngster in Shafali Verma has well and truly given way to a wiser allrounder, hungry to

contribute to a win in every way possible. Smriti Mandhana rose to the zenith of international cricket, leaving behind names who had influenced her in the sport. Sree Charani's incredible year kept getting better as she hacked down a number of records while reigning supreme in the T20I rankings.

Nothing came in the way: be it feeble attempts at a fightback from weaker opponents, an unforgiving travel itinerary that barely gave the team breathing space between the Asia Cup and the Asian Games, modest accommodation provisions or threats of a Japanese typhoon that ultimately steered clear of the Korogi Sports Park in Nisshin City.

Mismatch aplenty

Take away the passions of sporting merit from the consumption of these two tournaments, and the chronology and character pools are nearly identical. The traditional Asian top four — India, Sri Lanka, Pakistan and Bangladesh — are paired against starry-eyed gladiators emerging from the Qualifiers. Valiant campaigns and campaigners come up against the Full Members, akin to bringing a knife to a gunfight, and

eventually get found out.

In the Asia Cup, Indonesia, Thailand, Hong Kong China and UAE asked the occasional tough question but were ushered out of contention without much mercy. One's heart beats and breaks for the underdogs and keeps you invested long enough before you realise how every competition day across editions feels the same — lopsided contests, a glaring mismatch in resources and infrastructure, and a tape growing increasingly stale in an impatient consumer market where sport is primarily produced for broadcast.

The story was no different at the Asiad. While the big four — courtesy of some continuity gathered over their travels across the continent — found their rhythm, Thailand was the only constant among the rest, with Malaysia, China and Japan completing the pack. These are not random draws; qualifying tournaments guarded the gates to these stages. But as much as things change, teams improve or find their footing in the global game, the overall imbalance between the Associates and the Full Members stays the same.

Asian teams are playing more